

BEARDED DRAGON · *POGONA VITTICEPS*

Keep your bearded dragon the right way from day one.

A complete, fact-checked printable manual: setup, UVB, safe foods, health triage, and the routines that keep a dragon thriving for its full lifespan.

INSIDE

- ✓ Temperature, UVB and humidity targets in °F and °C
- ✓ Safe foods charts: 70+ insects, greens, vegetables and fruit
- ✓ Health triage, symptom table and an emergency card
- ✓ Owner logs, pet-sitter sheet and a power-outage plan

34 pages

Beginner to Intermediate

Print or tablet

Version 3.0 · Sep 2026



CONTENTS

What's inside

Every page is written to be used, not just read once.

GETTING STARTED

How to Use This Package	3
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SECTION 01 · QUICK PROFILE

Quick Profile & Cost Overview	4
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SECTION 02 · FULL CARE GUIDE

Housing & Enclosure	5
Temperature, UVB & Humidity	6
Thermostats, Timers & UVB Distance	7
Substrate, Furnishings & Handling	8
Diet & Feeding by Age	9
Feeder Insects: Staples, Treats & Never	10
Safe Greens & Vegetables	11
Fruit, Extras & the Never-Feed List	12
Common Mistakes & Enrichment	13
Sexing, Growth & Body Condition	14
Females, Eggs & Egg Binding	15

SECTION 03 · HEALTH & COMMON ISSUES

Health Red Flags & What to Tell the Vet	16
Metabolic Bone Disease & Impaction	17
Respiratory Infection, ADV & Yellow Fungus	18
Parasites, Mouth Rot, Tail Rot & Eye Problems	19
Brumation, Stuck Shed & Glass Surfing	20
Reading Poop & Keeping a Dragon Hydrated	21

SECTION 04 · QUICK REFERENCE

Setup Checklist & Temperature Targets	22
Emergency & Quick Targets Card	23

SECTION 05 · OWNER TOOLS

Budget & Shopping List	24
First 30 Days Checklist	25
Symptom Quick Reference	26
Daily, Weekly & Seasonal Routine	27
Power Outages, Travel & Transport	28
Pet-Sitter Sheet	29
Owner Log	30
Equipment, Supplement & Vet Log	31
Enrichment Checklist & Log	32

REFERENCE

Glossary	33
Sources, Version History & About	34

START HERE

How to use this package

Three ways to get value from it, depending on where you are right now.

If you haven't set up yet

Read pages 4 through 12 in order before buying anything. Housing, temperature, and UVB decisions are expensive to redo. Get the enclosure size and lighting right the first time, then use the Budget & Shopping List on page 24 to buy once.

If your dragon is already set up

Jump to the Setup Checklist and Temperature Targets on page 22 to audit what you have, and the Health Red Flags section starting on page 16 if anything seems off. The Safe Foods charts on pages 10 to 12 are worth a read even for experienced keepers, since most diet problems come from a food that was fine "once in a while" becoming a daily habit.

Print these first

- | | |
|---|---|
| ☐ Page 22: Setup Checklist & Temperature Targets | ☐ Page 29: Pet-Sitter Sheet |
| ☐ Page 23: Emergency & Quick Targets Card | ☐ Page 30: Owner Log |
| ☐ Page 26: Symptom Quick Reference | ☐ Page 31: Equipment, Supplement & Vet Log |
| ☐ Page 27: Daily, Weekly & Seasonal Routine | ☐ Page 32: Enrichment Checklist & Log |

WHY THIS PACKAGE EXISTS

Bearded dragon husbandry has moved on from a lot of what older care sheets still say. This package reflects current UVB, enclosure-size, and diet standards, cross-checked against veterinary and herpetological sources (listed on page 34), not recycled forum advice. Every temperature and dimension is given in both imperial and metric.

NOT A SUBSTITUTE FOR

A reptile-experienced veterinarian. This is a husbandry reference for day-to-day care. Anything urgent or health-related is always a vet call, not a page in this book. Find a reptile vet before you need one and write the number on page 23.

SECTION 01

Quick profile

Everything at a glance before you read the detail.

Scientific name	<i>Pogona vitticeps</i> (inland or central bearded dragon)
Adult size	16 to 24 in (41 to 61 cm) nose to tail; 300 to 500 g typical, big males heavier
Captive lifespan	10 to 15 years typical with consistent care, occasionally longer
Native range	Arid and semi-arid woodland, scrubland and rocky desert of inland eastern Australia
Diet type	Omnivore, ratio shifts from insect-heavy to plant-heavy with age
Enclosure minimum (adult)	4×2×2 ft (120×60×60 cm, about 120 gal), front-opening preferred
UVB requirement	Ferguson Zone 3 open basker: linear T5 HO tube, basking-spot UVI 4.0 to 4.5
Sexual maturity	Around 12 to 18 months; females can lay infertile eggs without a male (page 15)
Handling difficulty	Beginner to intermediate; generally tolerant once settled
Conservation status	Least Concern (IUCN)

Cost overview

Initial setup

\$420 to \$860 for equipment, plus \$75 to \$200 for the first vet exam and fecal test.

Monthly ongoing

\$60 to \$130 for feeders, greens, supplements, electricity, bulbs and the yearly vet visit, averaged.

BUDGET FOR THE WORST CASE TOO

Emergency care isn't rare enough to ignore. Impaction surgery commonly runs \$800 to \$2,500; MBD treatment \$200 to \$500+. Neither is likely if you follow this package, but both are real enough to plan for.

Fun facts worth knowing

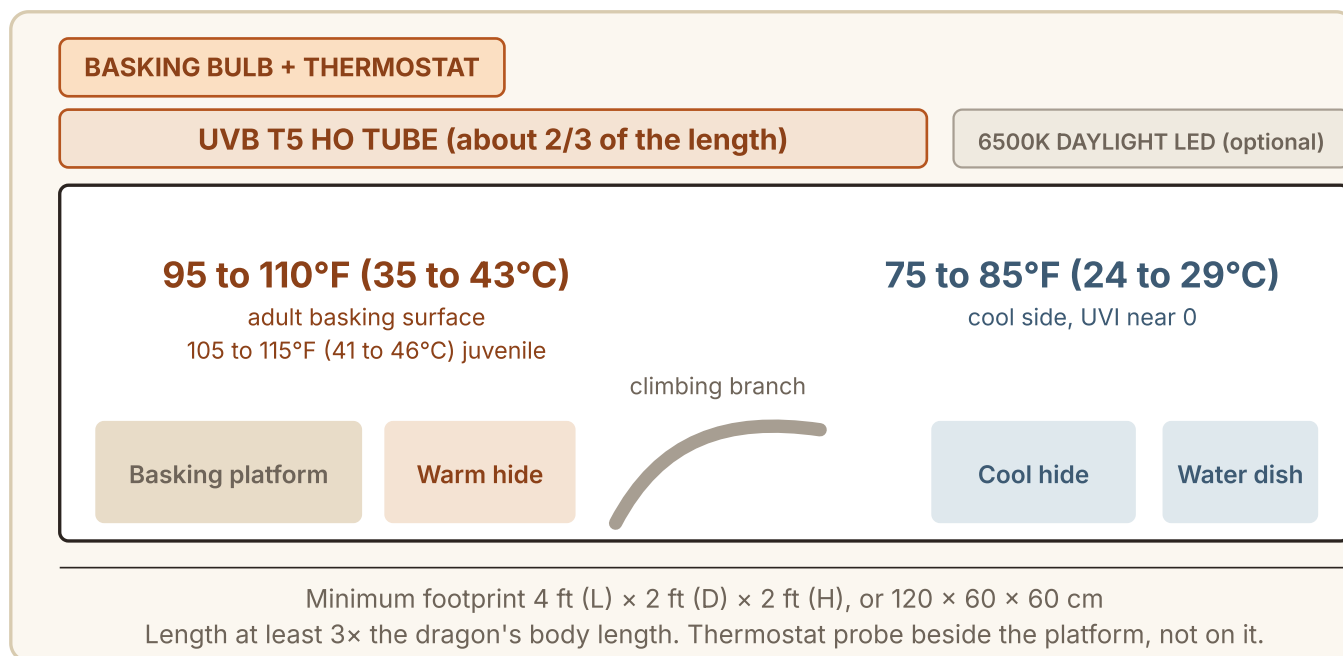
- The "beard" is a flap of spiny skin under the chin that darkens and puffs out during stress, territorial display, or breeding, not a sign of aggression by itself.
- They darken their backs to absorb heat when cool and lighten when warm. University of Melbourne researchers measured the effect in wild dragons.
- They can see ultraviolet light through a fourth type of cone cell, which is part of why lighting affects appetite and mood, not just bones.

SECTION 02 · FULL CARE GUIDE

Housing & enclosure

4×2×2 ft (120×60×60 cm, roughly 120 gallons) is the adult minimum, not an upgrade to get around to eventually. As a rule of thumb, enclosure length should be at least three times your dragon's total body length. A front-opening enclosure makes daily handling and cleaning far easier than a top-opening one.

PVC or sealed wood enclosures with glass fronts hold heat far better than all-glass tanks and are what most experienced keepers use. A glass tank works, it just needs stronger heating to hold the gradient, and a screen top changes the UVB mounting distance (page 7).



NEVER

House two bearded dragons together. They are solitary and will stress, fight, or resource-guard even in large enclosures. Cohabitation is not "social enrichment" for this species.

What the diagram doesn't show

- Cover three sides of the enclosure to cut down on reflections. A dragon that repeatedly mistakes its reflection for a rival can develop chronic stress.
- Skip hot rocks and unguarded heat sources entirely. They're the most common cause of thermal burns and add nothing a proper basking setup doesn't already do better.
- Two hides minimum, one on each end, so your dragon never has to choose between security and temperature. Anchor everything an adult can climb so nothing shifts under its weight.

Temperature, UVB & humidity

ZONE	TARGET (°F)	TARGET (°C)
Basking surface, adult / juvenile	95 to 110 / 105 to 115	35 to 43 / 41 to 46
Warm side (ambient air, not the basking surface)	about 90	about 32
Cool side	75 to 85	24 to 29
Nighttime low	65 to 75	18 to 24
Humidity	30 to 40% baseline. Brief spikes after a soak are normal; days above 50 to 60% cause respiratory and skin trouble.	

Measure the basking surface with an infrared thermometer aimed at the platform, not the air. Add overnight heat only if the room drops below 65°F (18°C), using a ceramic heat emitter or deep heat projector on a thermostat, never a colored bulb.

Two fixtures, not one

UVB and heat are separate jobs. A T5 HO UVB tube gives UV but almost no heat. Pair it with a separate halogen or incandescent flood (\$25 to \$50) over the same platform, run through a dimming thermostat (page 7), and confirm the surface temperature with the infrared thermometer rather than trusting the wattage.

UVB is not optional

This is the one piece of equipment worth spending real money on. Use a linear T5 HO tube (Arcadia 12% Desert or Zoo Med ReptiSun 10.0), spanning about two-thirds of the enclosure length on the basking side, never behind glass or plastic, which block UVB almost entirely. Mesh blocks a third to a half, so the mounting distance on page 7 depends on whether a screen is in the way. Coil bulbs are not adequate.

UVI targets

Bearded dragons are Ferguson Zone 3 open baskers. Aim for a gradient from 0 on the cool side up to **4.0 to 4.5** at the basking spot, or **3.0 or lower** for hypomelanistic, silkback, and translucent morphs, which burn more easily.

Bulb schedule

Run 10 to 14 hours a day on a timer. Replace every 6 to 12 months for T5 HO, every 6 months for T8. Output fades long before the bulb dims, so replace by the calendar and write the date on page 31.

Signs your setup needs adjusting

YOU NOTICE	LIKELY MEANS
Glass fogging or condensation	Humidity too high, or too little ventilation
Stays on the highest perch, rarely basks	Basking spot too cool, or too far away
Digs at the coolest corner, gapes, sits in the water	Enclosure too hot overall, no real cool side
Avoids the basking area, squints under the light	UVI too strong or bulb too close, or surface too hot

Thermostats, timers & UVB distance

The thermostat is the safety device

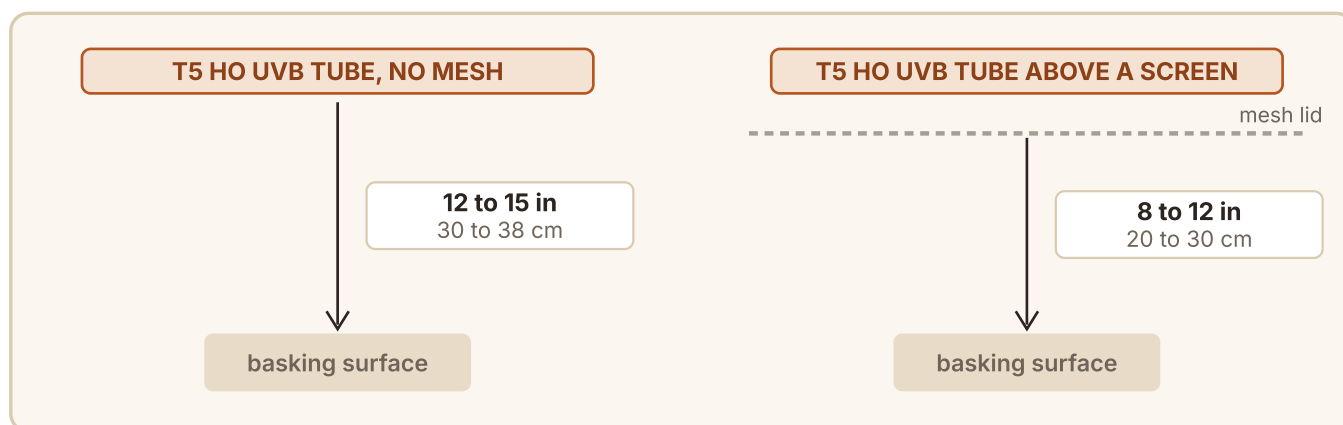
A thermostat sits between the heat source and your dragon and stops a bulb that reads 105°F this morning from overshooting badly on a warm afternoon. Use a **dimming (proportional) thermostat** for halogen or incandescent basking bulbs: it turns the power down instead of switching the bulb off and on, which halogens hate and which makes the light flicker. Use an **on/off or pulse thermostat** for a ceramic heat emitter or deep heat projector. Put the probe beside the basking platform, not on it and never on the cool side. Never put the UVB tube on a thermostat, and never run any heat source unregulated.

Wattage is a starting guess, not a target. A 50 to 75 W halogen flood usually reaches adult basking temperature in a 4×2×2 ft enclosure at 8 to 12 in (20 to 30 cm); a cool room or a big platform may need 100 W or two smaller bulbs side by side for a wider hot spot. Let the thermostat and the infrared thermometer settle it.

Timers and the light schedule

Put every light on a plug-in timer so the day length never depends on you remembering. 12 to 14 hours of light in summer and 10 to 12 in winter matches the natural cycle, and the seasonal shift is often what cues brumation (page 20). All lights and heat go off at night unless the room falls below 65°F (18°C); then use a ceramic heat emitter or deep heat projector on its own thermostat. Skip red, blue, and "moonlight" night bulbs entirely.

UVB mounting distance



Distances are for a 12% Desert or ReptiSun 10.0 T5 HO. Higher-output tubes such as the Arcadia 14% Dragon need more, typically 15 to 18 in (38 to 45 cm) with no mesh. Follow the chart for the exact bulb, and treat mesh as a 30 to 50% loss.

MEASURE, DON'T ASSUME

A Solarmeter 6.5 costs about one vet visit and removes the guesswork: read the UVI at the basking spot, adjust the height to 4.0 to 4.5, and re-check every three months to catch a fading bulb.

Substrate, furnishings & handling

Substrate

Paper towel, newspaper, or tile are the safest options, especially while you're new. Experienced keepers sometimes run a bioactive substrate (a deep naturalistic mix with live plants and a cleanup crew of isopods and springtails), but it's a bigger commitment and not where most people should start. A separate dig box (page 13) gives a dragon on tile somewhere to dig.

NEVER

Loose sand (including calcium sand), crushed walnut shell, wood chips, or gravel. All carry a real impaction risk if ingested, whatever the label says (page 17).

Furnishings checklist

- | | |
|---|--|
| ☐ Basking platform (rock, slate, or sturdy wood) directly under the lamp | ☐ Shallow water dish the dragon can climb out of easily |
| ☐ Two hides: one warm side, one cool side | ☐ Food dish or slate for greens, wiped daily |
| ☐ Sturdy, well-anchored climbing branches at more than one height | ☐ Dig box, and a deeper lay box for adult females (page 15) |

Handling

Give a new dragon 7 to 14 days to settle before handling beyond feeding and cleaning. Approach from the side or below, never from above, which reads as a predator strike. Scoop from underneath, supporting chest, belly, and all four feet, never by the tail, and keep early sessions to 5 to 10 minutes. A dragon that flattens, darkens its beard, gapes, or hisses is telling you to stop; end the session calmly. Once it's eating normally, short daily sessions build trust faster than occasional long ones.

- Don't handle within about an hour of a meal. Dragons need to bask to digest, and handling too soon can cause regurgitation.
- Handle low, over a bed or couch. Bearded dragons have no fear of heights and will launch off a hand without warning.

SALMONELLA

Healthy reptiles carry *Salmonella* with no sign of it. Wash your hands with soap before and after handling, keep the dragon and its gear away from food-prep areas, and never clean dishes in the kitchen sink. Children under five, pregnant people, and anyone immunocompromised should avoid handling.

First days in a new home

Days 1 to 3: hands-off except feeding and spot-cleaning. Days 4 to 7: calm presence near the enclosure, hand resting inside at feeding time. Days 7 to 14: first short handling sessions once appetite and stool look normal; shorter and more frequent for juveniles.

SECTION 02 · FULL CARE GUIDE

Diet & feeding by age

Bearded dragons are omnivores, and the ratio flips dramatically with age. This mirrors a real dietary shift documented in wild dragons, not an arbitrary husbandry rule. Only feed when the basking surface is at temperature; a dragon that can't bask can't digest.

AGE	INSECTS	GREENS / VEG	INSECT FEEDINGS	HOW MUCH
Hatchling (0 to 4 mo)	about 80%	about 20%	2 to 3× daily	As many small insects as eaten in 10 to 15 min. Fresh greens available every day even if ignored.
Juvenile (4 to 12 mo)	70 to 80%	20 to 30%	1 to 2× daily	Same 10 to 15 minute rule. Greens daily; most start eating them around 6 months.
Sub-adult (12 to 18 mo)	about 50%	about 50%	Once daily to every other day	Taper insects down as growth slows. Salad daily.
Adult (18 mo+)	20 to 30%	70 to 80%	2 to 4× per week	About 10 to 20 insects per feeding, adjusted to body condition (page 14). Salad daily, a pile about the size of the head.

Supplement schedule

SUPPLEMENT	HATCHLING & JUVENILE	ADULT	NOTES
Plain calcium (no D3, phosphorus-free)	At one feeding every day	2 to 3× per week	The everyday dust. Light coating, not a snowball.
Calcium with D3	Replaces plain calcium 2× per week	1× per week	A backup to UVB, not a substitute. Gravid females need more calcium, ask your vet (page 15).
Multivitamin (reptile-specific)	1× per week	1× per week	Skip the D3 calcium that day if the multivitamin already contains D3.

WHY NOT D3 AT EVERY FEEDING

Under a correct T5 HO tube the dragon makes its own D3. Adding supplemental D3 at every feeding on top of that risks vitamin D toxicity, which calcifies soft tissue and is far harder to treat than a calcium shortfall. Plain calcium is the daily dust; the D3 version is insurance.

Gut-loading

Feed the feeder insects for 24 to 48 hours before they go in: leafy greens, carrot, squash, or a commercial gut-load. What the insect ate last is what your dragon gets, and dusting does not replace it. Feeders are on page 10, plants on pages 11 and 12, hydration on page 21.

NEVER FEED

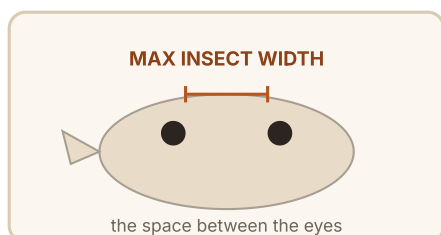
Avocado, rhubarb, fireflies, wild-caught insects, or any insect wider than the space between your dragon's eyes. The full never-feed list is on page 12.

SECTION 02 · FULL CARE GUIDE

Feeder insects: staples, treats & never

Captive-bred only, gut-loaded, and no wider than the space between the eyes.

INSECT	TIER	NOTES
Dubia roaches	STAPLE	The best all-round feeder: good protein, low fat, easy to gut-load, quiet, no smell, and they can't climb smooth plastic.
Black soldier fly larvae (BSFL, CalciWorms)	STAPLE	Naturally calcium-rich, soft and small, ideal for hatchlings and juveniles. Keep the calcium schedule anyway.
Crickets	STAPLE	Cheap and active, which triggers hunting. Gut-load well and remove any left at lights-out; loose crickets nibble a sleeping dragon.
Silkworms	STAPLE	Soft, high moisture, low fat and readily eaten. Pricier and short-lived, so buy small batches.
Locusts / grasshoppers (captive-bred)	STAPLE	Common in the UK and EU. Excellent nutrition and a strong hunting response. Never wild-caught.
Hornworms	OCCASIONAL	Mostly water: great for hydration or tempting a dragon off food, poor as a staple. They grow fast, so re-check the size daily.
Earthworms (pesticide-free source, not bait shop)	OCCASIONAL	Safe now and then; many dragons ignore them.
Mealworms	OCCASIONAL	Hard chitin shell and fatty. Adults only, a few at a time, never for juveniles.
Superworms	OCCASIONAL	Fatty and they bite. Adults only, tong-fed, never left loose in the enclosure.
Waxworms	TREAT ONLY	Very high fat and habit-forming. A few per week at most, none for an overweight dragon.
Butterworms	TREAT ONLY	Fatty but calcium-rich. Same limits as waxworms.
Freeze-dried or canned insects	TOPPER ONLY	Little nutrition and no moisture. Fine sprinkled on salad, never the insect ration.
Fireflies (lightning bugs)	NEVER	Contain lucibufagin toxins. A single firefly can kill a bearded dragon.
Wild-caught insects, spiders, centipedes	NEVER	Pesticide and parasite risk, and some are venomous or toxic.
Ladybugs, boxelder bugs, stink bugs, monarch caterpillars	NEVER	Toxic or foul-tasting. Not worth the gamble even from a garden you don't spray.



Sizing, storage and gut-loading

Prey wider than the gap between the eyes is a choking and impaction risk, and for juveniles it can cause hind-leg weakness. When in doubt, go smaller and feed more. Keep feeders in a ventilated tub with a dry food (oats or a commercial gut-load) plus fresh greens, carrot, or squash for moisture, and never feed an insect that smells off or came from a tub with dead ones in it.

SECTION 02 · FULL CARE GUIDE

Safe greens & vegetables

Staples have more calcium than phosphorus and little oxalate. Build the salad from them; add variety from the lower tiers.

FOOD	TIER	NOTES
Collard greens	STAPLE	Backbone green: very high calcium, low oxalate, cheap all year.
Mustard greens	STAPLE	High calcium, peppery, well accepted. Rotate with collards.
Turnip greens	STAPLE	Same class as collards. Leaves only; the root is occasional.
Dandelion greens and flowers	STAPLE	Excellent calcium. Store-bought, or from ground never sprayed.
Endive and escarole	STAPLE	Mild, good calcium, often the first green a picky dragon takes.
Watercress, arugula (rocket)	STAPLE	Strong flavor, good nutrition. Fine in the rotation.
Cactus pad (nopál), spines removed	STAPLE	High calcium and hydrating. Sold in many grocery stores.
Winter squash (butternut, acorn), raw and grated	STAPLE	The staple vegetable. Grate finely; no need to cook.
Green beans, snap peas	STAPLE	Chop small. Good texture variety.
Bell pepper, okra, yellow summer squash	STAPLE	Small amounts. Good vitamins; a few pieces mixed in, not the salad base.
Kale, bok choy, cabbage, broccoli	OCCASIONAL	Goitrogens. A couple of times a week in rotation, never daily.
Carrot, sweet potato (raw, grated)	OCCASIONAL	High in vitamin A. A pinch for color and variety.
Zucchini, cucumber, romaine, celery	OCCASIONAL	Mostly water. Fine for hydration, useless as a staple.
Cilantro, basil, parsley, mint	OCCASIONAL	Scent tempts picky eaters. Parsley is high oxalate, keep it small.
Tomato, peas, corn, asparagus	RARE	Acidic or phosphorus-heavy. A few pieces now and then.
Spinach, Swiss chard, beet greens	RARE	High oxalate binds calcium. Not toxic, but never a regular food.
Iceberg lettuce	SKIP	Just water. Causes runny stool and teaches dragons to ignore greens.
Avocado, rhubarb, onion, garlic, leek, chives	NEVER	Toxic. Avocado (persin) and rhubarb (oxalic acid) can be fatal.
Raw potato, nightshade leaves, mushrooms	NEVER	Nightshade toxins, or no benefit and real risk.

Wash, chop to bite size, and replace the salad daily. If greens are refused, offer them before insects in the morning with a little grated squash or a berry mixed in. Juveniles often ignore salad until about 6 months; keep offering it.

SECTION 02 · FULL CARE GUIDE

Fruit, extras & the never-feed list

Fruit is a treat: about 5 to 10 percent of the plant portion, once or twice a week.

FOOD	TIER	NOTES
Figs, papaya, prickly pear fruit	OCCASIONAL	The best fruits: better calcium balance than most. Still a treat.
Berries: strawberry, blueberry, raspberry, blackberry	OCCASIONAL	Chop small. A good "hide the medicine" or picky-eater food.
Mango, melon, apple and pear (cored), peach, apricot, plum (no pit)	OCCASIONAL	Sugary and mostly water. A few small pieces mixed into greens.
Banana, grapes (halved), kiwi	RARE	High phosphorus or sugar. A tiny amount, rarely.
Citrus: orange, lemon, lime, grapefruit, pineapple	NEVER	Acidic; causes stomach upset and diarrhea.
Dried fruit, fruit pits and seeds, canned fruit in syrup	NEVER	Concentrated sugar, choking risk, or cyanide-containing seeds.

Extras and "human food" questions

ITEM	VERDICT	NOTES
Commercial pellets or salad toppers	OCCASIONAL	Fine sprinkled on greens for variety, never the main diet.
Bee pollen	OCCASIONAL	A pinch on salad as an appetite booster. Optional.
Pinky mice	RARE	Not needed in captivity. Only if a reptile vet suggests it for a specific reason.
Eggs, meat, chicken, fish	NEVER	Wrong protein and fat balance for this species.
Dog, cat, or rabbit food	NEVER	Nutritionally wrong for this species and hard on the kidneys.
Bread, pasta, dairy, chips, anything processed	NEVER	No benefit. Reptiles can't digest lactose at all.

THE NEVER-FEED LIST, IN ONE PLACE

Avocado · rhubarb · onion, garlic, leek, chives · citrus · raw potato, nightshade leaves and stems · mushrooms · fireflies · any wild-caught insect · ladybugs, boxelder bugs, stink bugs, monarch caterpillars · any insect wider than the space between the eyes · eggs, meat, dairy, pet food, processed food · anything sprayed with pesticide. Houseplants count during free-roam: pothos, philodendron, ivy, lilies, daffodils, and oleander are all toxic.

BUILDING THE DAILY SALAD

Two or three staple greens chopped fine, one staple vegetable grated on top, and a pinch from the occasional tier. Rotate the greens weekly, and dust the salad with plain calcium on days without insects.

Common mistakes & enrichment

Mistakes that cause the most harm

- Undersizing the enclosure "because it's just a baby," then never upgrading once it's an adult.
- Buying a UVB bulb once and never tracking its replacement date, or running a coil bulb and assuming it counts.
- Running a basking bulb with no thermostat, or putting the probe on the cool side where it never triggers.
- Skipping the cool side entirely, leaving no way for the dragon to thermoregulate down.
- Dusting calcium with D3 at every feeding on top of strong UVB, or skipping calcium entirely because "the UVB handles it."
- Feeding an adult like a juvenile, leading to obesity and fatty liver over time. Waxworms and superworms as a daily food are the usual culprits.
- Trusting packaging that says "reptile safe" without checking whether it's actually safe for this species. Loose sand is the classic example.
- Skipping quarantine when introducing a new reptile, or sharing tools and feeder tubs between animals of unknown health status.
- Estimating UVI by eye instead of measuring it. Output can look bright while still being too weak, or too strong for a sensitive morph.

Enrichment, by priority

Enrichment comes after correct heat, UVB, diet, and enclosure size, never instead of them. In this order:

1. Climbing structure

Sturdy branches, cork, and ledges at varied heights let a dragon survey from above and choose its own distance from the heat. Anchor everything; unstable stacked rocks are a crush-injury risk.

2. Dig box

A tub the dragon can turn around in, filled 4 to 6 in (10 to 15 cm) deep with a 50/50 mix of organic topsoil and washed play sand, kept slightly damp. Never calcium sand. Adult females need a deeper version (page 15).

3. Visual security

Partial barriers, plants, or a half-covered side let a dragon retreat from view without leaving the warm zone, which lowers baseline stress in busy rooms.

4. Foraging and hunting

Tong-feeding, short supervised insect hunts inside the enclosure, and scatter-fed or hung greens all engage natural behavior. Remove uneaten insects before lights-out.

5. Supervised free-roam

10 to 15 minutes to start, building toward 30 for some adults, in a warm draft-free room with gaps blocked, other pets out, cords and toxic plants removed. End it if the dragon cools, panics, or blackens its beard. Never unsupervised, never in a cold room, never a glass enclosure left in direct sun.

6. Novelty rotation

Reposition one furnishing every few weeks. Constant rearranging is stressful; a recognizable layout with one new thing is the sweet spot.

Sexing, growth & body condition

Telling male from female

Reliable from about 4 to 6 months. In a dim room, gently lift the tail to about 90 degrees and shine a phone flashlight down through the base of the tail from above. **Males** show two hemipenial bulges, one either side of a central dip, just past the vent. **Females** show a single central bulge or nothing at all. Adult males also have larger, waxy femoral pores along the inside of the thighs, a broader head, and a bigger beard display. Pet-store sexing of hatchlings is a guess; recheck at 6 months.

Growth reference

Ranges are deliberately wide and healthy dragons fall outside them. What matters is the trend: steady gain for a juvenile, a stable weight for an adult. Weigh weekly in grams on a kitchen scale and log it on page 30.

AGE	TOTAL LENGTH	WEIGHT
Hatchling (0 to 1 month)	3 to 4 in (8 to 10 cm)	under 10 g
2 months	5 to 9 in (13 to 23 cm)	10 to 40 g
3 to 4 months	8 to 12 in (20 to 30 cm)	30 to 90 g
5 to 6 months	11 to 16 in (28 to 41 cm)	80 to 200 g
8 to 10 months	13 to 20 in (33 to 51 cm)	150 to 350 g
12 months	16 to 22 in (41 to 56 cm)	250 to 450 g
18 months and up (adult)	16 to 24 in (41 to 61 cm)	300 to 500 g typical; large males heavier

Body condition at a glance

UNDERWEIGHT

Hip bones and spine visible, tail base thin and triangular instead of round, the fat pads on top of the head sunken into hollows, eyes sunken. Skin wrinkles when the dragon isn't shedding. Rule out parasites and low temperatures first (page 19), then feed up under vet guidance.

IDEAL

Tail base full and rounded, head fat pads level with the skull, belly flat and off the ground when standing, a defined waist from above. Weight stable week to week in an adult, climbing steadily in a juvenile.

OVERWEIGHT

Bulging fat pads on the head, jowls under the jaw, rolls at the armpits, a tail base thicker than the thighs, belly dragging. Common in adults fed like juveniles. Cut fatty feeders, shift toward salad, add climbing and free-roam. Fatty liver disease is the long-term risk.

WHEN A WEIGHT CHANGE IS A VET VISIT

A juvenile that stops gaining for 3 to 4 weeks. An adult that loses about 10 percent of its body weight outside brumation, or any weight loss that comes with appetite loss, lethargy, or abnormal stool. Bring the Owner Log; a trend line tells a vet more than a single reading.

Females, eggs & egg binding

Every female owner needs this page, whether or not a male has ever been in the house.

Females lay without a male

From roughly one to two years old, many females develop egg follicles and lay infertile clutches, typically 15 to 30 eggs, sometimes two or three clutches in a season. Some never do. Neither is a problem by itself. What matters is recognizing it and giving her somewhere to dig.

Signs she is gravid

- A big appetite for a few weeks, then going off food in the one to two weeks before laying.
- Restlessness, digging at corners, glass surfing, pacing the enclosure, especially in the afternoon.
- A rounder belly that feels like a bag of marbles when she walks. Never squeeze to check; eggs bruise easily.

The lay box

A container she can turn around in, filled 6 to 12 in (15 to 30 cm) deep with a 50/50 mix of organic topsoil and washed play sand, damp enough that a tunnel holds its shape without dripping. Put it on the warm side as soon as you see the signs and leave it until she's done. She may dig several test holes over a few days, then lay in one sitting and fill it in. Remove infertile eggs afterward. She'll be thin and hungry: feed well, dust plain calcium daily for two weeks, and offer a soak.

CALCIUM DEMAND GOES UP

Making eggs pulls calcium from her bones. Correct UVB and the supplement schedule on page 9 cover most of it; ask your vet about a temporary increase during a cycle, and never guess at doses. A female that cycles constantly is worth a vet conversation about long-term options, including spaying.

Egg binding (dystocia) is an emergency

Eggs that she cannot pass. It develops from low calcium, no lay site, obesity or poor muscle tone, or oversized or malformed eggs. Call a reptile vet the same day if you see any of these:

- Digging and straining for more than 24 to 48 hours with no eggs, or a partial clutch and then she stops and looks exhausted.
- Lethargy, sunken eyes, hind-leg weakness, refusing water, or a lump in the belly that doesn't shift over days.
- Any female past the "off food" stage who is losing condition rather than laying.

Treatment ranges from fluids and calcium to induced laying or surgery. The longer it waits, the fewer options remain. A lay box that is always available to an adult female is the cheapest prevention there is.

Health red flags

What to watch for, and what to actually tell the vet.

CONTACT A REPTILE VET PROMPTLY IF YOU SEE

A juvenile refusing food for 2 to 3 days, or an adult for 1 to 2 weeks outside genuine brumation · sunken eyes · black beard combined with lethargy · limb swelling, limping, tremors, or trouble lifting the body · discharge from eyes, nose, or mouth · diarrhea lasting more than 2 days · straining without producing waste, or no stool in 5+ days (sooner in a juvenile that normally goes daily) · any tissue protruding from the vent · a gravid female digging for 48 hours with no eggs.

What to tell the vet

- ☐ Current basking and cool-side temps, and how you measured them
- ☐ UVB bulb brand, type, age, distance, and whether there's mesh in the way
- ☐ Diet breakdown (insects vs. greens) and supplement schedule over the last 2 weeks
- ☐ When symptoms started and whether they're worsening
- ☐ Last normal bowel movement, and what it looked like
- ☐ Weight trend from the Owner Log, and a fresh stool sample in a sealed bag if you can

Why UVB and temperature come up first

Most of the serious conditions in this section (MBD, respiratory infection, impaction, and appetite loss) trace back to a UVB or temperature problem more often than anything else. A vet will ask about your setup before anything else for exactly that reason. The Association of Reptilian and Amphibian Veterinarians keeps a searchable directory of reptile-experienced vets; find one before you need one and write the number on page 23.

Normal vs. concerning

NORMAL	CONCERNING
Black beard for a few hours during shedding, stress, or a territorial moment, then back to normal color	Black beard lasting multiple days, especially paired with lethargy or appetite loss
An adult skipping a meal occasionally, especially in cooler weather	A juvenile refusing food for more than 2 to 3 days, or an adult for more than 1 to 2 weeks outside brumation
Brief lethargy right after a big meal or during a shed cycle	Persistent lethargy with no clear trigger, or lethargy with weight loss
Dull, grey-looking skin for a few days before a shed	Yellow, crusty, or blackened patches of skin that spread

Metabolic bone disease & impaction

Metabolic Bone Disease (MBD)

Cause: insufficient UVB, insufficient calcium, or too much phosphorus relative to calcium, over weeks to months. Juveniles under two are hit hardest because their bones are still forming. **Early signs:** twitching toes, a slight tremor when held, reluctance to climb, a jaw that looks a little soft or receded. **Later signs:** swollen or rubbery jaw, bowed limbs, a kinked tail or spine, difficulty walking or lifting the body, bones that fracture easily, and in severe cases seizures. **Diagnosis:** physical exam plus an X-ray to check bone density, sometimes a blood calcium panel. **Response:** vet diagnosis and treatment immediately. This does not self-correct and worsens quickly. Typical treatment cost runs \$200 to \$500+. **Recovery:** early, mild cases improve over weeks to months with corrected UVB and vet-guided calcium therapy; advanced bone deformity usually remains even after the disease itself is controlled.

WHILE YOU WAIT FOR THE APPOINTMENT

Remove climbing furniture and lower the basking platform. A dragon with weakened bones can fracture a limb in a fall that wouldn't hurt a healthy one. Handle as little as possible and support the whole body when you must.

PREVENTION BEATS TREATMENT

Correct UVB (pages 6 and 7) and the calcium schedule on page 9 prevent nearly all MBD cases. This is the single highest-leverage thing in this whole package.

Impaction

Cause: loose substrate, oversized or hard-shelled feeder insects, dehydration, or temperatures too low to digest properly. **Signs:** straining without producing waste, a firm lump along the belly, lethargy, loss of appetite, and in juveniles hind-leg weakness or dragging. **Diagnosis:** physical palpation and an X-ray to locate and size the blockage. **Recovery:** mild, early cases sometimes resolve with vet-guided warm soaks, fluids, and gentle belly massage; surgery is reserved for blockages that don't pass on their own.

CONCRETE THRESHOLD

If your dragon hasn't defecated in five or more days, or a juvenile that normally goes daily hasn't in three, it's time to see a vet. Don't wait longer to "see if it resolves." Surgery, when needed, commonly runs \$800 to \$2,500.

Respiratory infection, ADV & yellow fungus

Three conditions worth knowing by name before you ever see them.

Respiratory Infection (RI)

Cause: most often prolonged cool temperatures or humidity that sits high for days. **Signs:** open-mouth breathing at rest, audible clicking or wheezing, mucus or bubbles at the nose or mouth, puffing the throat repeatedly, lethargy, loss of appetite. **Diagnosis:** physical exam and listening to the lungs; the vet will ask about your temperature setup directly. **Response:** vet visit for antibiotics; correct the temperature and humidity setup in parallel or it recurs. Occasional gaping while basking is normal thermoregulation, not RI.

Atadenovirus (ADV)

What it is: a contagious virus, most damaging in young dragons, spread by direct contact and by feces on shared tools, dishes, hands, and enclosures. **Signs:** failure to thrive, stunted growth, chronic poor condition despite correct husbandry, weakness, and neurological signs, most distinctively "stargazing," where the dragon holds its head tilted up and back. **Reality check:** there is no cure, only supportive care, and some infected adults show nothing while shedding the virus. A vet can test a new dragon with a PCR swab. Quarantine any new reptile for 60 to 90 days in a separate room with separate tools, and never share feeder tubs between animals of unknown status.

Yellow Fungus Disease

What it is: a contagious, aggressive fungal skin infection caused by *Nannizziopsis guarroi* (long grouped under the older name CANV). **Signs:** yellow, tan, or brown discolored, crusty, or thickened patches of skin, often starting on the head, limbs, or belly, sometimes with a foul odor, that spread and ulcerate over weeks. **Diagnosis:** skin biopsy or culture. **Response:** months of antifungal treatment and strict isolation from other reptiles. Prognosis ranges from guarded to poor, so early treatment matters. It spreads by contact and shared substrate or tools.

THE COMMON THREAD

All three are far less common in a correctly heated, correctly lit, single-dragon enclosure with good quarantine hygiene for anything new. Prevention here is mostly husbandry, not luck.

Parasites, mouth rot, tail rot & eye problems

Less dramatic than the last page, and far more common.

Internal parasites

Pinworms and coccidia are common even in dragons from good breeders. Low pinworm counts often cause no trouble; coccidia in a juvenile can. **Signs:** runny or foul-smelling stool, undigested food, weight loss, poor appetite, lethargy. Many infections are silent. **Response:** a fecal exam (\$30 to \$60) on the first vet visit and every year after, with a fresh sample less than 24 hours old in a sealed bag. Never deworm blindly with an over-the-counter product; the dose depends on the parasite and the weight.

Mouth rot (infectious stomatitis)

Signs: swollen or bleeding gums, yellow-white cheesy material in the mouth, drooling, refusing food, a jaw that looks puffy on one side. Dark or stained teeth on their own are normal in adults. **Cause:** stress, low temperatures, a mouth injury from live prey or hard food, sometimes secondary to MBD. **Response:** vet visit for cleaning and antibiotics. It spreads to the jawbone if ignored.

Tail rot and toe loss

Signs: the tail tip or a toe turns dark, dry, and hard, and the dark area creeps upward over days. **Cause:** stuck shed cutting off circulation, an injury, a bite from a cage mate or a feeder insect, or a fall. **Response:** vet promptly. Caught early it may be treatable; advanced cases need the dead section amputated to stop it spreading. Check toes and tail tip at every shed (page 20).

Eye problems

Eyes held shut or puffy for a day or two during a head shed is normal. Swollen, closed, or weeping eyes that last longer usually point to the UVB bulb being too close or too strong (coil bulbs at short range are the classic cause), a vitamin A imbalance, a scratch, or an infection. Check the bulb distance on page 7 first; vet if it persists beyond two days or comes with discharge.

Burns and prolapse

Burns from hot rocks, an unguarded bulb, or a basking surface over temperature show as blistered, blackened, or peeling skin on the back or belly. Cool the area with room-temperature water, fix the heat source, and see a vet for anything more than a small red patch. **Prolapse** is pink or red tissue protruding from the vent that doesn't retract within minutes. Keep it moist with a clean wet cloth or saline, never push it back, and get to a vet the same day.

Brumation, stuck shed & glass surfing

Brumation

A natural winter slowdown in appetite and activity, most common in dragons over a year old and triggered by shorter days and cooler nights. Signs include reduced eating, more time hiding, sleeping earlier, and lower activity over several weeks. Confirm with a vet check and fecal test first to rule out illness, then let it happen. Don't force-feed. Typical brumation runs 1 to 3 months. Check in with a vet if it stretches past about three and a half months, comes with more than 10 percent weight loss, or appetite hasn't returned within 2 to 3 weeks of waking.

THE BRUMATION ROUTINE

Weigh weekly. Offer a shallow lukewarm soak once a week and fresh greens every few days, but no insects while the dragon can't bask to digest them. Shorten the light cycle to 8 to 10 hours on a timer, or leave lights off if it's fully asleep in a hide, and keep the room from dropping below 65°F (18°C). Resume the normal schedule the day it reappears and starts basking.

Stuck shed (dysecdysis)

Most common on toes, the tail tip, and around the eyes, where low humidity or poor circulation interferes with normal shedding. Increase local humidity briefly with a damp towel or a shallow lukewarm soak, and never peel unshed skin by force. Toe and tail-tip stuck shed can cut off circulation if left unaddressed (page 19). A shallow soak two or three times a week during a shed cycle prevents most cases before they start. Juveniles shed every few weeks; adults a few times a year.

Glass surfing

Repetitive pacing or scratching along the glass. Work through the usual causes in order: a reflection or another pet in view; an enclosure that's too small or too hot with no real cool side; boredom or hunger; and, in an adult female, a gravid dragon looking for somewhere to lay (page 15). Cover reflective surfaces on three sides and reduce disruptive activity near the enclosure before assuming it's just "personality." Fixing the underlying trigger resolves it faster than covering glass alone.

QUICK DIFFERENTIATOR

Brumation is slow and low-energy. Glass surfing is repetitive and high-energy. If you're not sure which you're seeing, the energy level is usually the tell.

Reading poop & keeping a dragon hydrated

Stool is the earliest free health check you get. Look at it before you clean it up.

IT LOOKS LIKE	USUALLY MEANS	DO
Firm brown log with a white to off-white soft urate	Normal	Nothing. Juveniles go about daily, adults every 1 to 4 days, less in brumation.
Urate yellow, orange, or hard and chalky	Dehydration, or excess calcium being passed	Soak, mist the salad, offer hydrating foods. Vet if it persists a week or the dragon looks sunken.
Runny, watery, or foul-smelling for more than 2 days	Parasites, especially if there's mucus; or too much fruit, hornworms, or watery greens	Cut the watery foods first. If it continues, vet with a fresh sample.
Undigested insect parts	Basking temperature too low, or prey too large	Re-measure the basking surface and downsize the insects.
Black, tarry, or with red streaks	Possible blood in the digestive tract	Vet the same day.
Only urate, no feces, for several days	Not eating, or brumation	Check appetite and temps; see the refusal thresholds on page 16.
Nothing at all for 5+ days (3 in a juvenile that eats)	Possible impaction	Vet promptly (page 17).

Hydration

Most of a dragon's water comes from food. Many barely touch a dish, some drink from one regularly, so keep a shallow dish available and refresh it daily. Beyond that:

- Mist the salad, not the enclosure walls. Water droplets on greens get eaten; a damp enclosure just raises humidity.
- A shallow lukewarm soak, 15 to 20 minutes, once or twice a week, chest-deep at most and never unsupervised. Most dragons drink during it.
- Hydrating foods: hornworms, silkworms, cucumber or melon pieces, cactus pad, as extras rather than staples.
- A dragon that won't drink: drip water onto the snout with a syringe or dropper and let it lick. Never squirt water into the mouth.

SIGNS OF DEHYDRATION

Wrinkled or loose skin outside a shed, sunken eyes, thick or stringy saliva, yellow or hard urates, lethargy, and skin that stays tented for a moment when gently pinched on the side. Mild cases respond to soaks and food; a dragon that is sunken and lethargic needs a vet for fluids.

Setup checklist & temperature targets

Essential setup checklist

- ☐ 4×2×2 ft (120×60×60 cm) enclosure, front-opening
- ☐ Linear T5 HO UVB tube at the distance on page 7 (12 to 15 in with no mesh)
- ☐ Separate halogen or incandescent basking bulb (UVB alone won't provide heat)
- ☐ Dimming thermostat on the basking bulb, probe beside the platform
- ☐ Plug-in timer for every light
- ☐ Infrared thermometer gun for surface temperature
- ☐ Digital thermometer and hygrometer on each end
- ☐ Basking platform and two hides (warm and cool)
- ☐ Paper towel, newspaper, or tile substrate
- ☐ Shallow water dish and a food dish or slate
- ☐ Plain calcium, calcium with D3, and a reptile multivitamin
- ☐ Feeding tongs and a kitchen scale that reads in grams
- ☐ Feeder insect setup or supplier, and a greens plan
- ☐ UVB replacement date written on page 31

Temperature & climate targets

TARGET	°F	°C
Basking surface, adult / juvenile	95 to 110 / 105 to 115	35 to 43 / 41 to 46
Warm side (ambient, not basking)	about 90	about 32
Cool side	75 to 85	24 to 29
Nighttime low	65 to 75	18 to 24
Humidity	30 to 40% baseline	
UVI at basking spot	4.0 to 4.5 (3.0 or lower for hypo, silkback, and translucent morphs)	
Light cycle	12 to 14 hours summer, 10 to 12 hours winter, on a timer	

Before your dragon comes home

- ☐ Enclosure fully set up and running for 24 to 48 hours first
- ☐ Basking and cool-side temps confirmed with a thermometer, not by feel
- ☐ Thermostat tested: watch it dim the bulb as the probe warms
- ☐ UVB fixture mounted at the correct distance and tested
- ☐ Feeder insect and greens source lined up before day one
- ☐ Reptile vet found and first appointment booked (page 25)

Emergency & quick targets

CALL A REPTILE VET NOW IF

No stool in 5+ days (3 in a juvenile) · open-mouth breathing at rest, wheezing, or mucus · limb swelling, tremors, seizures, or inability to lift the body · sunken eyes with lethargy · a juvenile off food 2 to 3 days, an adult 1 to 2 weeks outside brumation · tissue protruding from the vent · a female digging 48 hours with no eggs · a burn, a spreading dark patch on tail or toes, or black or bloody stool

READING	°F	°C
Basking surface, adult / juvenile	95 to 110 / 105 to 115	35 to 43 / 41 to 46
Warm side (ambient)	about 90	about 32
Cool side	75 to 85	24 to 29
Nighttime low	65 to 75	18 to 24
Humidity	30 to 40%	
UVI at basking spot	4.0 to 4.5 (3.0 or lower for sensitive morphs)	
UVB bulb replacement	Every 6 to 12 months (T5 HO) · every 6 months (T8)	
Calcium	Plain daily for juveniles, 2 to 3× a week for adults · D3 version 1 to 2× a week · multivitamin weekly	

Your numbers

Reptile vet _____

UVB bulb installed _____

24-hour exotic emergency clinic _____

Replace UVB by _____

Dragon's name and hatch date _____

Last vet visit _____

HAVE THIS READY WHEN YOU CALL

Basking and cool-side temps, UVB bulb type and age, last bowel movement and what it looked like, current weight and the trend, and diet over the last two weeks. Transport in a ventilated tub with a towel, kept warm (page 28).

Budget & shopping list

US retail ranges. The low end is basic but correct gear; the high end is premium PVC and name-brand lighting.

INITIAL SETUP	TYPICAL COST
4×2×2 ft enclosure (PVC, or wood with a glass front)	\$200 to \$400
Linear T5 HO UVB fixture + bulb	\$60 to \$110
Halogen basking bulb + dome fixture	\$25 to \$50
Dimming thermostat	\$40 to \$80
Infrared thermometer gun	\$15 to \$30
Digital thermometer/hygrometer (two) and plug-in timers	\$20 to \$40
Substrate (tile or paper towel)	\$0 to \$40
Hides, basking platform, branches, dishes, tongs, scale	\$60 to \$110
Equipment subtotal	\$420 to \$860
First vet exam and fecal test	\$75 to \$200
All-in before the dragon arrives	\$500 to \$1,050

MONTHLY ONGOING	TYPICAL COST
Feeder insects (less as an adult)	\$25 to \$50
Greens and vegetables	\$10 to \$25
Calcium and multivitamin	\$5 to \$10
Electricity for heat and lighting	\$10 to \$20
UVB and basking bulb replacement, averaged	\$5 to \$10
Annual wellness exam and fecal, averaged	\$5 to \$15
Monthly ongoing	\$60 to \$130

PLAN FOR, DON'T COUNT ON AVOIDING

Impaction surgery \$800 to \$2,500 · MBD treatment \$200 to \$500+ · egg binding \$300 to \$1,500 depending on whether it needs surgery. A few hundred dollars set aside matters as much as any item on this list.

WHERE NOT TO CUT CORNERS

The UVB fixture, the thermostat, and the enclosure size are the three line items most directly tied to the health conditions in this package. Save on decor before you save here. Substrate can genuinely be free.

First 30 days checklist

Day 1

- ☐ Weigh the dragon in grams and photograph it and the setup for a baseline
- ☐ Confirm basking surface, cool side, and night temps with the infrared gun and a digital thermometer, not "feels warm"
- ☐ Fill in the numbers on page 23 and the equipment dates on page 31

Week 1

- ☐ Let your dragon settle: minimal handling, focus on feeding and watching appetite and stool
- ☐ Book a wellness visit with a reptile vet for within the first two weeks; save a fresh stool sample the morning of for a fecal test
- ☐ Measure UVI with a Solarmeter if you have one, or verify the mounting distance against page 7

Week 2 to 3

- ☐ Begin short, gentle handling sessions if appetite and behavior look normal
- ☐ Settle into a consistent feeding and supplement schedule from page 9, and start the salad habit even if it's ignored
- ☐ Start the Owner Log on page 30 with a weekly weigh-in

Week 4

- ☐ Review the weight trend. Steady gain is the goal for a juvenile, stable weight for an adult
- ☐ Set a phone reminder for the UVB replacement date and a monthly thermostat check
- ☐ Introduce the first enrichment items from page 32

Days 31 to 90

- ☐ Book any follow-up the vet recommended, and act on the fecal result if parasites showed up
- ☐ Re-measure UVI directly if you have access to a meter; don't rely on the bulb's age alone
- ☐ Look back at the Owner Log for any slow drift in weight, appetite, or temps
- ☐ Start rotating enrichment on the monthly schedule from page 32, and fill in the pet-sitter sheet on page 29 before you need it
- ☐ Recheck the sex at 6 months (page 14) and add a lay box if it's a female

Symptom quick reference

SYMPTOM	LIKELY CAUSE	ACTION
Black beard plus lethargy	Stress, illness, or brumation	Check temps first; vet if it lasts days
No stool 5+ days (3 in a juvenile)	Impaction	Vet promptly (page 17)
Twitching toes, tremors, soft or swollen jaw	Metabolic bone disease	Vet immediately; remove climbing items (page 17)
Open-mouth breathing at rest, wheezing, mucus	Respiratory infection	Vet promptly; fix temps and humidity (page 18)
Head tilted up and back, wobbling, failure to thrive	Atadenovirus or other neurological cause	Vet, isolate from other reptiles (page 18)
Yellow or crusty skin patches that spread	Yellow fungus	Vet and isolate (page 18)
Swollen gums, cheesy material in mouth	Mouth rot	Vet (page 19)
Tail tip or toe turning dark and dry	Tail rot, stuck shed	Vet promptly (page 19)
Eyes swollen or closed more than 2 days	UVB too close or strong, vitamin A, infection	Check bulb distance; vet if it persists (page 19)
Pink or red tissue from the vent	Prolapse	Keep moist, vet same day (page 19)
Blistered or blackened skin	Burn	Fix heat source; vet (page 19)
Stuck shed on toes or tail	Low humidity or circulation	Damp towel or soak (page 20)
Repetitive glass scratching	Reflection, size, heat, boredom, gravid	Work the list on page 20
Reduced appetite, adult, cooler months	Possible brumation	Vet check first, then let it happen (page 20)
Female digging, restless, off food	Gravid	Lay box now; vet if 48 h with no eggs (page 15)
Runny or smelly stool 2+ days	Parasites, diet, stress	Cut watery foods; vet with fresh sample (page 21)
Yellow or hard urates, wrinkled skin	Dehydration	Soak and hydrating foods (page 21)
Weight loss between log entries	Several possible causes	Vet, bring the Owner Log (page 30)
Bulging head fat pads, jowls, belly dragging	Obesity	Cut fatty feeders, more salad and activity (page 14)
Gaping while basking, otherwise normal	Normal thermoregulation	Nothing, unless it comes with wheezing or mucus

Daily, weekly & seasonal routine

Daily

- ☐ Glance at basking and cool-side temps on the digital thermometers
- ☐ Fresh salad in the morning; insects per the age schedule on page 9
- ☐ Dust supplements on the right days (page 9)
- ☐ Refresh the water dish; remove uneaten insects before lights-out
- ☐ Spot-clean stool and look at it before you do (page 21)
- ☐ Quick visual check: eyes, beard, posture, belly, appetite

Weekly

- ☐ Weigh in grams and log it on page 30
- ☐ Wipe down glass, dishes, and the basking platform
- ☐ Optional 15 to 20 minute soak, more often during a shed
- ☐ Check the basking surface with the infrared gun
- ☐ Rotate the greens so no single one is the whole salad

Monthly

- ☐ Full substrate change and enclosure deep clean with a reptile-safe disinfectant, rinsed well
- ☐ Confirm the thermostat still cuts in and the timers are on schedule
- ☐ Review the Owner Log for slow trends, not just single readings
- ☐ Reposition one furnishing; check climbing items still fit the dragon's size

Every 3 months

- ☐ Measure UVI with a Solarmeter if you have one; adjust height or replace the bulb
- ☐ Check nails and tail tip for overgrowth or old stuck shed

Seasonal

- ☐ Shift the timer: 12 to 14 hours of light in summer, 10 to 12 in winter
- ☐ Reassess room temperature swings; add night heat only if the room drops below 65°F (18°C)
- ☐ Watch for early brumation signs in fall (page 20); book the pre-brumation vet check
- ☐ Adult females: lay box ready from late winter through summer (page 15)

Yearly

- ☐ Wellness exam and fecal test
- ☐ Replace the UVB bulb (or at 6 months for T8)

Power outages, travel & transport

A healthy adult tolerates one cool night without harm. The risk is days without heat, and feeding a dragon that can't digest.

When the power goes out

Do

- Keep the dragon above 60°F (16°C). Below that for more than a day or two is when problems start.
- Drape thick towels or a blanket over the enclosure, leaving a vent gap, to hold what heat is left.
- Move the enclosure, or the dragon in a tub, to the warmest room in the house.
- Use hand warmers or a hot-water bottle wrapped in a towel, placed beside the dragon, never touching it.
- Stop feeding insects. Offer greens and water only until the basking spot is back.
- Past two days below 65°F (18°C), board it with a vet, a friend with power, or a reptile shop.

Don't

- Don't use candles, gas stoves, or open flame anywhere near the enclosure.
- Don't put a heat pack in direct contact with the dragon; it can't move away fast enough and will burn.
- Don't feed insects "to keep its strength up." Undigested food in a cold gut rots.
- Don't warm a cold dragon in hot water; lukewarm only, and only once it's alert.

OUTAGE KIT

Hand warmers, a hot-water bottle, two thick towels, a battery thermometer, a ventilated tub, and the vet numbers from page 23.

Leaving town

TRIP LENGTH	ADULT	JUVENILE (UNDER 12 MONTHS)
1 to 2 nights	Fine alone. Lights on timers, thermostat on, fresh salad and water before you go. No insects needed.	A sitter once a day for insects, greens, water, and a temperature check.
3 to 7 nights	A sitter every 1 to 2 days for greens, water, a stool check, and a temperature check. Insects twice in the week.	A sitter daily. Leave pre-portioned insects and written instructions (page 29).
Over a week	A daily sitter who has done a practice visit with you, or boarding with a reptile-experienced vet or shop. Never a friend's cat-and-dog boarding.	

Transport and vet trips

- A ventilated plastic tub or small carrier with a towel to grip, in a dark room-temperature bag or box. No loose substrate, no water dish.
- Warm the car before loading in cold weather; a wrapped hand warmer beside the tub for trips over 30 minutes below 65°F (18°C).
- Don't feed insects the morning of a trip. Never leave the dragon in a parked car, hot or cold, even briefly.
- Moving house: set the enclosure up and running at the new place before the dragon arrives, same as day one.

FILL IN AND LEAVE BY THE ENCLOSURE

Pet-sitter sheet

Everything a sitter needs on one page. Walk them through it once in person before the first solo visit.

Dragon's name _____

Age and normal weight _____

My phone _____

Reptile vet _____

24-hour emergency clinic _____

Backup contact _____

Each visit

- ☐ Check the thermometers. Warm end should read about 90°F (32°C), cool end 75 to 85°F (24 to 29°C). Lights should be on between _____ and _____.
- ☐ Fresh chopped salad in the dish: _____ (see the bag in the fridge). Throw out yesterday's.
- ☐ Insects on these days: _____. Give about _____ from the tub, one at a time with the tongs. Remove any left after 15 minutes.
- ☐ Dust with the calcium jar on _____ (light coating on the insects or salad).
- ☐ Rinse and refill the water dish.
- ☐ Scoop any poop with a paper towel. Normal is a brown log with a white end.
- ☐ Wash your hands before and after. Don't rinse anything in the kitchen sink.

Please don't

- Take the dragon out of the enclosure, unless we agreed on it. It can jump from your hands and doesn't know it can't fly.
- Change any dial, timer, or thermostat setting, or move the lights.
- Feed anything not on this sheet, and never lettuce, fruit, or anything from the garden.
- Spray the enclosure with water; a damp tank is bad for it.

CALL ME IF

The lights are off during the day or the warm end reads below 80°F (27°C) · the dragon is breathing with its mouth open at rest, or there's mucus at the nose · it hasn't moved from the same spot on two visits · the beard has been black all visit · there's runny or bloody poop, or none for three days · anything is protruding from the tail end · it's digging frantically and won't stop · anything else that looks wrong. If I don't answer, call the vet number above.

Owner log

A steady weight trend is the single best early warning system you have. Most of the conditions in this package show up as a weight change before anything else is visible. Sixteen rows is four months; that's long enough to see a real trend.

Equipment, supplement & vet log

Equipment log

ITEM	INSTALLED	REPLACE OR CHECK BY	DONE
UVB bulb (6 to 12 months for T5 HO)			
Basking bulb			
Thermostat function check (monthly)			
Thermometer and hygrometer batteries			
Solarmeter UVI reading at basking spot			
Calcium and multivitamin opened (replace yearly)			

Twelve-month planner

Tick the box in the month you did it. Start with whichever month you're in.

TASK	M1	M2	M3	M4	M5	M6	M7	M8	M9	M10	M11	M12
Deep clean	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Thermostat check	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
UVI reading	☐			☐			☐			☐		
UVB bulb replaced						☐						☐
Vet exam and fecal	☐											☐
Timer shifted for season			☐						☐			

Vet visit log

DATE	WEIGHT (G)	REASON AND FINDINGS	FOLLOW-UP

Enrichment checklist & log

Setup

- ☐ Climbing branches or ledges at two or more heights, securely anchored
- ☐ Basking platform the dragon can fully stretch out on
- ☐ Dig box, 4 to 6 in (10 to 15 cm) of topsoil and play sand
- ☐ Lay box available for adult females in season (page 15)
- ☐ At least two hides at different enclosure temperatures
- ☐ Partial visual barrier on the busy side of the room

Monthly review

- ☐ Reposition one furnishing to refresh the layout
- ☐ Offer a scatter-feed, a hung salad, or a supervised insect hunt at least once
- ☐ Supervised free-roam in a warm, escape-proof room at least once
- ☐ Reassess whether climbing and basking items still fit current body size
- ☐ Try one new safe food from pages 11 and 12

Enrichment log

DATE	ACTIVITY	HOW IT WENT, AND WHETHER TO REPEAT

FREE-ROAM SAFETY, EVERY TIME

Warm room, no drafts, gaps under furniture blocked, other pets out, cords and houseplants out of reach, and a hand within grabbing distance of any height. Back in the enclosure at the first sign of cooling, panic, or a black beard.

Glossary

ADV	Atadenovirus: a contagious, incurable viral infection of bearded dragons; prevention relies on quarantine and testing.
Brumation	A reptile's natural winter dormancy: reduced activity and appetite for weeks to months, distinct from illness.
Dimming thermostat	A thermostat that lowers the power to a heat bulb instead of switching it off and on. The right kind for halogen and incandescent basking bulbs.
Dysecdysis	Incomplete or "stuck" shedding, most often affecting toes, the tail tip, and the eyes.
Dystocia	Egg binding: a female unable to pass her eggs. A same-day emergency.
Ferguson Zone	One of four categories matching a species' natural sun exposure to a UVB strength. Bearded dragons are Zone 3, open or partial-sun baskers.
Goitrogens	Compounds in kale, cabbage, and broccoli that interfere with the thyroid in large, regular amounts. Fine in rotation, not as a daily staple.
Gravid	Carrying eggs. Females can be gravid without ever meeting a male.
Gut-loading	Feeding nutritious food to feeder insects for 24 to 48 hours before offering them, so the nutrition passes through.
Hemipenal bulges	The two bumps at the base of a male's tail, visible with a flashlight from about 4 to 6 months of age.
Impaction	A gastrointestinal blockage, often from substrate, oversized prey, dehydration, or low digestion temperatures.
MBD	Metabolic Bone Disease: weakened, deformed bones from inadequate UVB or calcium.
Oxalates	Compounds in spinach, chard, beet greens, and parsley that bind calcium so it can't be absorbed. Why those foods are rare, not staple.
Photoperiod	The number of hours of light per day. 12 to 14 in summer, 10 to 12 in winter, set by a timer.
Quarantine	Keeping a new or unwell reptile fully separate from others, with separate tools and hand-washing between animals, for 60 to 90 days.
Stargazing	Holding the head tilted up and back for long periods. A neurological sign, most often linked to ADV. Urgent, not wait-and-see.
T5 HO	A high-output linear fluorescent tube format. The standard UVB source for this species; coil and compact bulbs are not equivalent.
Urate	The white, semi-solid part of reptile waste, the equivalent of urine. Its color and texture are a hydration gauge.
UVI	UV Index: the measurement scale used to describe basking-spot UVB intensity, read with a Solarmeter 6.5.
Yellow fungus	<i>Nannizziopsis guarroi</i> (historically grouped as CANV), a contagious, aggressive fungal skin infection.

REFERENCE

Sources, version history & about

Where the numbers in this package come from, so you can check them yourself.

Veterinary and scientific sources

- VCA Animal Hospitals: Bearded Dragons, the feeding, housing, and diseases articles.
- University of California, Davis, School of Veterinary Medicine: Bearded Dragon Care.
- North Carolina State University Veterinary Hospital: How to Feed Your Bearded Dragon.
- Washington State University Veterinary Teaching Hospital: Yellow Fungus Disease in Bearded Dragons.
- Merck Veterinary Manual: nutritional and metabolic bone disease in reptiles.
- Association of Reptilian and Amphibian Veterinarians (ARAV): reptile lighting and vitamin D3 guidance, and the find-a-vet directory.
- Baines et al., "How much UV-B does my reptile need?", Journal of Zoo and Aquarium Research (2016), the Ferguson Zone framework.
- Smith et al., "Colour change on different body regions provides thermal and signalling advantages in bearded dragon lizards", Proceedings of the Royal Society B (2016).
- Centers for Disease Control and Prevention: Healthy Pets, Healthy People, reptiles and *Salmonella*.

Husbandry references

- ReptiFiles: Bearded Dragon Care Guide, temperatures, UVB, and the atadenovirus article.
- Arcadia Reptile: T5 UVB mounting distance charts for the Desert 12% and Dragon 14% lamps.
- Zoo Med Laboratories: ReptiSun T5 HO distance and replacement guidance.
- Beastly Facts bearded dragon guides: tank setup, feeding, health issues, handling, cost, and enrichment, current at the time of publication.

Version history

VERSION	WHAT CHANGED
3.0 · Sep 2026	Rebuilt and expanded from 22 to 34 pages. Corrected the supplement schedule (plain calcium daily, D3 as a backup), split food-refusal thresholds by age, added metric units throughout, thermostat and UVB-distance page, full feeder and safe-foods charts, sexing and growth, females and egg binding, parasites and minor conditions, poop and hydration, power-outage and travel plan, pet-sitter sheet, longer logs, and this sources page.
2.0 · Aug 2026	Second edition, 22 pages.

This package is a husbandry reference compiled from the sources above and cross-checked against current veterinary guidance at the time of publication. It is not a substitute for a reptile-experienced veterinarian, and nothing in it should delay a vet visit. Free companion guides, updated as guidance changes, are at beastlyfacts.com.

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